“Stackolee”: A Floating Ballad Text

On Christmas night in St. Louis in 1895, two friends, William (Billy) Lyons and “Stack” Lee Shelton, stood drinking together at a bar in the city’s “bloody Third District,” “a predominantly African American neighborhood filled with saloons, small shops, cheap apartments, and music halls” (Eberhart 1996, 3). What started as a friendly conversation quickly escalated into murder. As George Eberhart recounts:

> Something sparked a disagreement, and Shelton and Lyons began to strike each other's hats. George McFaro, a laborer who lived in the neighborhood, testified that neither man looked drunk and it seemed as if they were just goofing around instead of fighting in anger…Shelton then grabbed Lyons's derby and broke it. Lyons retaliated by snatching Shelton's hat. Shelton demanded it back at least three times, but Lyons refused, saying that Stack would have to pay him 75 cents for his crushed hat…Then Shelton pulled out his gun, a Smith and Wesson .44, and threatened to blow his friend's brains out unless he returned his hat. Lyons told him to go ahead, so Shelton smacked Lyons on the head with his revolver…Lyons stumbled forward and reached into his pocket as if for a knife, once again demanding money and saying, “You cock-eyed son-of-a-bitch, I am going to make you kill me”…Shelton stepped back a pace or two and shot Billy Lyons once in the abdomen. Lyons fell back against the railing of the bar and staggered briefly, still clutching Stack's hat…Shelton…picked up his hat and walked coolly out of the saloon. (1996, 5, 7)

In the following years the character of Stack Lee Shelton became immortalized in the murder ballad “Stackolee”—or “Stagger Lee” or “Stagolee” or other similar variants—about a villain so fearsome that he would kill over the merest provocation. Most versions of the song describe Billy Lyons's plea for sympathy for his wife and small children, and Stackolee's merciless reply that he doesn't care about Billy's family, only the stolen hat. Some songs mythologize Stackolee's other exploits—like his intimidation of the devil upon his arrival in hell—and almost all versions describe him as "cruel," "bad," or "mean." Many versions depict him as a kind of irrepressible antihero, a source of pride and even emulation for following only his own ruthless code, for his unwillingness to suffer the indignity of someone touching his hat. Eberhart and others have given detailed historical accounts of Shelton's murder of Lyons and the emergence and popularization of the ballad.[1] This study will focus on the ballad's musical attributes and its combination with multiple formal patterns.

Unlike some other murder ballads that emerged around the turn of the twentieth century, including "Frankie and Johnny," "Railroad Bill," and "Whitehouse Blues," "Stackolee" does not associate exclusively with a particular poetic form, phrase rhythm, harmonic progression, or melodic design. Instead the ballad intermingles with multiple patterns, or schemes—preexisting musical frameworks that musicians use for the creation of songs.[2] In this regard "Stackolee" resembles a "floating stanza," a verse that crops up in multiple songs (Evans 1982, 130). But "Stackolee" is a "floating ballad," because the entire song floats between different musical schemes. Like the ancient ballad "Barbara

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[1]See, for example, Cecil Brown (2003). Brown argues that "Stagolee is a metaphor that structures the life of black males from childhood through maturity…Stagolee is an in-group catchword conveying knowledge of what it means to be a black man" (2–3).
[2]Like the eighteenth-century schemata explored by Gjerdingen (2007) and others, the schemes discussed here form part of a stock repertory shared by many musicians, but unlike those earlier schemata these all correspond on a one-to-one basis with the verses of a song.

Allen," "Stackolee" is, to use Charles Seeger's term, "promiscuous," because it associates with multiple musical frameworks rather than adhering to just one (Seeger 1966, 122).

"Stackolee" appears in two main forms: a twelve-bar form, which combines with the "Frankie and Johnny" and "Railroad Bill" schemes, both ballad schemes that mostly support narrative songs about historical events; and an eight-bar form, which combines with the "How Long" scheme, which otherwise supports first-person lyric songs with conventional blues themes such as love and day-to-day life (Evans 1982, 27).

The ballad's combination with different schemes demonstrates two different processes of lyrical development. Its association with the "Frankie" scheme shows how a musical pattern can be a vehicle for lyrical crosspollination: lyrics sometimes migrate between ballads that share the same scheme. Conversely, its combination with the "How Long" scheme shows how a musical pattern can be a means of lyrical divergence: a separate lyrical branch may emerge where a song combines with a different scheme.

Twelve-Bar Ballad Meter and the Eight-Bar Blues Form

The ballad "Stackolee" emerged around the turn of the twentieth century, at the same time as several other American murder ballads, including "Frankie and Johnny," which is based on Frankie Baker's killing of Allen Britt in St. Louis in 1899; "Railroad Bill," which describes the exploits of the martyred Black desperado Morris Slater; and "Whitehouse Blues," about the assassination of William McKinley in Buffalo in 1901 (Morgan 2017, 24–28; Cohen, Cohen, and McLucas 2021, 145–46; Cohen 2000, 122–31, 413–25).

“Frankie and Johnny,” “Railroad Bill,” and “Whitehouse Blues” all share the poetic form common to most early twentieth-century ballads: a rhyming AB couplet followed by a refrain. In this pattern, labeled ABR, the couplet is new in every verse and the refrain is the same, as in the following pairs of verses:

A Frankie was a good girl, everybody knows
B She paid a hundred dollars for Albert’s one suit of clothes
R He’s her man, and he done her wrong

A Frankie went down to the corner saloon, didn’t go to be gone long
B She peaked through the keyhole in the door, spied Albert in Alice’s arms
R He’s my man, and he done me wrong
(Mississippi John Hurt, “Frankie,” 1928)

A Railroad Bill ought to be killed
B Never worked and he never will
R Now I’m ‘a ride my Railroad Bill

A Railroad Bill done took my wife
B Threatened on me that he would take my life
R Now I’m ‘a ride my Railroad Bill
(Will Bennett, “Railroad Bill,” 1929)

A McKinley hollered, McKinley squalled

B Doc says, "McKinley, I can't find that ball"

R From Buffalo to Washington

A Hush up my little children, now don't you fret

B You'll draw a pension at your papa's death

R From Buffalo to Washington

(Charlie Poole with the North Carolina Ramblers, "Whitehouse Blues," 1926, first and third verses)[3]

But the similarities between "Frankie," "Railroad Bill," and "Whitehouse Blues" extend beyond their poetic forms to their rhythmic profiles. As shown in **Example 1(a)–(c)**, all three songs have twelve-bar verses divided into three four-bar groups, and each group corresponds to a line of text and a vocal phrase. There are eight metric positions on the level of the half-bar for each four-bar group, numbered 1 through 8 at the top of the example, and in all three songs the first two phrases end in position 7, on the downbeats of bars 4 and 8, and the third phrase ends in position 5, on the downbeat of bar 11—as illustrated by the brackets above the lyrics. The phrase rhythm can be labeled 7,7,5 to indicate the closing positions of its three phrases. The rhyming syllables of the couplet, shown in bold, thus fall in analogous metric positions in their four-bar groups, reinforcing the poetic rhyme with a "rhythmic rhyme." Many verses have a caesura in position 4 of

[3]Charlie Poole uses two refrains in his song; the other is "He is gone, long long time. Unless otherwise noted, the verses transcribed in the text and examples are the opening verses.

the first phrase, dividing the A line; and many verses of “Frankie” have no accent in position 4 of the second phrase, even if there is no literal caesura in the vocal line (Ex. 1[a], bar 6, on “say.”).[4]

Peter van der Merwe refers to this combination of ABR poetic form and 7,7,5 phrase rhythm as “ballad meter,” because it characterizes so many turn-of-the-century American ballads (2004, 447). From its earliest collected examples, “Stackolee” also appears in ballad meter, as in the version collected by John Lomax in 1910 and published in John and Alan Lomax’s *American Ballads and Folk Songs* in 1934 **(Ex. 1[d])**.

But the variability of “Stackolee” is already apparent in this early Lomax collection, where it elsewhere appears as a series of rhyming AB couplets without refrains, a version the collectors describe as a more modern variant:

A Stagolee, he was a bad man, and everybody knows
B He toted a stack-barreled blow gun and a blue steel forty-four

A Way down in New Orleans, called the Lyon Club
B Every step you walkin,’ you walkin’ in Billy Lyon’s blood

(After Lomax and Lomax, 1934, 96)

[4]Many of the examples, including Example 1, show a rhythmically simplified representation in which stressed syllables align with strong metric positions instead of falling in their actual anticipatory positions. Temperley (1999; 2018, 72–80) describes in detail the technique of anticipatory syncopation and its ubiquity in rock music, and how we can understand many syncopated lyrics in terms of a hypothetical “de-syncopated” version. His theory applies equally well to prewar blues and country music.

This version of “Stackolee” (**Ex. 2[d]**) has a phrase rhythm and rhyme placement common to many popular eight-bar blues songs, including “Trouble in Mind” (**Ex. 2[a]**), “How Long—How Long Blues” (**Ex. 2[b]**), and “Key to the Highway” (**Ex. 2[c]**). These songs have two phrases, the first ending in position 7 and the second in position 5, and often match in the placement of caesuras in positions 2 and 4, especially in the first phrase.

Ballad Schemes

Ballad *schemes* are combinations of ballad meter with specific harmonic progressions and melodic designs, patterns that support multiple songs. A ballad scheme typically takes the name of its most familiar song, as do the “Frankie and Johnny” and “Railroad Bill” schemes; but they also combine with different songs about other, usually historical, topics. For example, the “Frankie” scheme also combines with the “Boll Weevil” song, about the devastating infestation of cotton crops in the South in the early twentieth century. And both the “Frankie” and “Railroad Bill” schemes support the song “Delia,” about the teenager Moses Houston’s murder of his girlfriend Delia Green in Savannah in 1900 (van der Merwe 1989, 184–85, 199; Stoia 2013, 205–08; Polenberg 2015, 90–99).

In addition to their divergent texts, the differences between the “Frankie and Johnny” and “Railroad Bill” schemes lie in their harmonic progressions, melodic designs, and the details of their rhythmic profiles. The most obvious difference is harmony: although both follow the ubiquitous I–IV–I–V–I “chord row”—an abstract succession of harmonies that defines tonality in much prewar blues and country music—they distribute the chords in distinct harmonic rhythms (Blum 2004, 8, and Figure 5).

In the "Frankie and Johnny" scheme (**Ex. 3[a]**), the subdominant opens the second phrase and resolves back to the tonic after three bars, and the dominant opens the third phrase and resolves back to the tonic after two bars (as shown under the lyrics in Example 3). The harmonic rhythm in the "Frankie" scheme therefore correlates closely with the phrase rhythm and poetic form: the resolution to tonic in the second phrase falls in position 7, together with the phrase ending and rhyme; and the resolution to tonic in the third phrase falls in position 5, together with the phrase ending and closing syllable of the refrain.[5] Moreover, the placement of the non-tonic harmonies in stronger metric positions (bars 5–7 and 9–10) than their tonic resolutions emphasizes their harmonic dissonance and compulsion to resolve.[6]

In the "Railroad Bill" scheme (**Ex. 3[b]**), by contrast, the second phrase begins with the tonic and concludes on the subdominant; and the last phrase, the refrain, has a tonic–dominant–tonic progression.[7] "Railroad Bill" thus places the non-tonic harmonies in weaker metric positions—bars 7–8 and 10—than their surrounding tonic harmonies. But a common substitution places III♯ in bars 5–6 (**Ex. 3[c]**), which resolves deceptively

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[5]Matt BaileyShea examines comparable ways in which rhymes are "musically reinforced," and observes that "composers have been fusing cadences and rhymes for centuries" (2021, 68, 76). Similarly, Trevor de Clercq observes that "a musical parallelism is often reinforced in the domain of lyrics through a rhyme" (2012, 121).

[6]Here I follow the theory of hypermeter posited by Schachter ([1987] 1999, 80–83) and Temperley (2018, 82–84). Schachter observes that dissonances that "are strongly accented relative to their resolutions" create "conflict between accent and tonal stability" ([1976] 1999, 41–42).

[7]Booker T. Sapps's recording, the basis of Example 3(b), is a field recording made in Florida in 1935 whose lyrics are often unclear, so I base the words in the example—especially the B line—partly on Chapman J. Milling's 1937 transcription of "Delia Holmes," which has a matching A line (Milling 1937, 4). The melody and phrase rhythm in Milling's transcription match the "Railroad Bill" scheme too. The title of Sapps's song is given as "Frankie and Albert (Cooney and Delia)," but the song is clearly about Delia, not Frankie.

to IV in bars 7–8, emphasizing the more dissonant applied dominant through stronger metric placement.

The two schemes also differ in their melodic designs. The “Frankie and Johnny” pattern combines with a more diverse array of tunes. Its most recurrent melodic design, the “Frankie” tune (**Ex. 4[a]**), is characterized by arpeggiations of the tonic in bars 1–4, often with emphasis on and upper-neighbor motion around ^5; arpeggiation of the subdominant in bars 5–7, often with emphasis on and upper-neighbor motion around ^8; and a descent to ^5 on the downbeat of bar 8, where IV resolves to I with the completion of the rhyme. Naturally, the “Frankie” tune often combines with lyrics about Frankie and Johnny, but singers associate it with other ballad topics too, including the “Boll Weevil” song, and combine it with miscellaneous subjects, as in Frank Hutchison’s “All Night Long” (**Ex. 4[b]**). But musicians also use the “Frankie” scheme as a vehicle for original melodies—whether with a ballad topic or not—as Henry Thomas does in “Bob McKinney” (**Ex. 4[c]**).

The “Railroad Bill” scheme, by contrast, has a much more uniform melodic design, and is therefore “doubly predetermined” in its harmony and melody (Ward 1953, 415). Variants of the melodic design appear in Will Bennett’s “Railroad Bill” **(Ex. 5[a]**) and Frank Hutchison’s “Railroad Bill” (**Ex. 5[b]**). As shown in the abstraction in **Example 5(c)**, the melody either prolongs ^3 over the first four bars or begins on ^5 in bar 1 before dropping to ^3 by the end of the phrase. The second phrase essentially descends from ^3 prolonged over the tonic to ^1 over the subdominant; but if III♯ substitutes in bars 5–6 then the melody typically moves through ^2, the chordal seventh, which resolves down by step to ^1 over the subdominant in bar 7. The end of the second phrase often climbs up to ^2 in bar 8, leading up to the ^3 in bar 9 that marks the first downbeat of the refrain. The last phrase essentially descends from ^3 in bar 9 to ^1 in bar 11, often passing through ^2 in bar 10 to match the shift to the dominant.

Finally, although the "Frankie" and "Railroad Bill" schemes share the 7,7,5 phrase rhythm, they differ significantly in the rhythmic details of their refrains (**Ex. 6**). The "Frankie" refrain has only two downbeat accents—the combination of a stressed syllable with a metrically strong downbeat position—falling in bars 9 and 11, or positions 1 and 5, for example on "man" and "wrong" in the common "Frankie" refrain line "He was my man, but he done me wrong" (**Ex. 6[a]**). But the "Railroad Bill" refrain has three downbeat accents, in bars 9, 10, and 11, or positions 1, 3, and 5, for example on "ride," Rail-," and "Bill" in the refrain "Now I'm 'a ride my Railroad Bill" (**Ex. 6[b]**). The accent patterns in these refrains are in turn closely intertwined with the harmonic rhythm: the "Frankie" refrain has only two harmonic shifts, to V and then back to I, whereas the "Railroad Bill" refrain has three harmonic shifts, to I, V, and then I. (Both graphics show the harmony that precedes the refrain, in bar 8, to clarify that the harmony changes in bar 9.) In both refrains, then, each chordal shift coincides with a downbeat accent, so that the harmonic rhythm matches the rhythmic profile.

Eight-Bar Blues Schemes

An eight-bar blues scheme, like a ballad scheme, usually takes the name of its most familiar song—as do the "Trouble in Mind," "How Long," and "Key to the Highway" schemes—while also carrying songs with different lyrics and topics (**Ex. 7**). These schemes, like the eponymous songs shown in Example 2, are identical in their 7,5 phrase rhythm, and many realizations correspond in the placement of caesuras in positions 2 and 4, especially in the first phrase. They differ in their harmonic progressions, melodic designs, and also to some extent in their poetic forms: the “Trouble in Mind” and “Key to the Highway” schemes have one rhyming AB couplet per verse (**Ex. 7[a–b]**), whereas the “How Long” scheme has both this form and an ABR form (**Ex. 7[c]**), in which the couplet spans the first phrase, with rhymes in the analogous positions 3 and 7, and the refrain spans the second phrase.

The “Trouble in Mind” scheme, like the “Railroad Bill” scheme, is doubly predetermined, whereas the “Key to the Highway” and “How Long” schemes carry a more diverse array of melodic material.[8] The “How Long” scheme is the most elusive of the three, the pattern whose parameters are hardest to specify.[9] It has a recurrent melodic design, the “How Long” tune (**Ex. 8**), characterized especially by its opening stepwise descending gesture between positions 1 and 3—either from ^8 to ♭^7, as in Leroy Carr and Scrapper Blackwell’s “How Long—How Long Blues” (**Ex. 8[a]**) or from ^3 to ^2, as in Blind Willie McTell and Ruby Glaze’s “Lonesome Day Blues” (**Ex. 8[b]**).

The first phrase usually ends with another, typically larger descent in bars 3–4, usually from ^8 down to ^1; but there are numerous variants. To take just one instance of melodic divergence, Carr’s octave descent in bars 3–4 expands the melody into the lower register, whereas Glaze’s expands it into the upper register.

The most consistent characteristics of the second phrase are its landing on a member of the tonic triad in position 1 and ending on ^1 in position 5, alighting on

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[8]For a detailed discussion of the “Trouble in Mind” and “Key to the Highway” schemes, including their melodic designs, see Stoia (2013, 204–05, 208–09).
[9]On the “How Long Blues” as a “ground,” see also Bowers and Westcott (1992, 189).

different degrees in position 3 in the many melodic variants. Carr’s melody, for instance, has ^1, ^$\underline{5}$, and ^1 marking positions 1, 3, and 5 (Ex. 8[a]; the underline indicates the degree below the final tonic), whereas Glaze’s has ^5, ^4, and ^1 in those positions (Ex. 8[b]). Glaze’s melody is also more rhythmically active than many realizations of the “How Long” tune, with an accent in position 6 in the first phrase and positions 2 and 4 in the second, like the “Trouble in Mind” scheme and some realizations of the “Key to the Highway” scheme.

The “How Long” scheme is also more flexible in its harmony than either the “Trouble in Mind” or “Key to the Highway” schemes, whose specific progressions are defining characteristics. The most distinguishing harmonic characteristics of the “How Long” scheme are its opening two-bar tonic prolongation—which supports the opening ^8–♭^7 or ^3–^2 gesture, and distinguishes the progression from the opening I-V motion of the other two eight-bar schemes—and its motion to IV in bar 3. If the descending ^8–♭^7 gesture is absent from the vocal part, it appears in the accompaniment, as shown below the staff in Example. 8[b], and thus forms part of the harmonic fabric of the scheme, transforming the opening I into the dominant of the following IV. The subdominant often spans bars 3–4 (Ex. 8[a] and [b]), but in some realizations it resolves back to I in bar 4, as in Peg Leg Howell’s “Rolling Mill Blues” (**Ex. 8[c]**). The most common progression in the second phrase is I–V–I in positions 1, 3, and 5 (Ex. 8[a], [b], and [c]).

Example 9, a graphic illustration of the “How Long” scheme, is an attempt to demonstrate the pattern’s defining characteristics while still allowing for its flexibility. The brackets show the obligatory 7,5 phrase rhythm, a defining element. The dots give more detail to the rhythmic profile: the un-parenthesized ones show which positions are consistently accented, and the parenthesized ones the positions that are sometimes accented. These details show the range of the scheme's rhythmic profile within the parameters of the 7,5 phrase rhythm: some realizations are much more sparsely accented, with only seven accents, on the downbeats of bars 1–7 (e.g., Carr's "How Long—How Long Blues," Ex. 8[a]); whereas others may have ten accents (e.g., McTell and Glaze's "Lonesome Day Blues," Ex. 8[b]), like most realization of the "Trouble in Mind" scheme (Ex. 7 [a]) and many realizations of the "Key to the "Highway" scheme (Ex. 7[b]).

The most consistent harmonic and melodic attributes—including the opening ^8–♭^7/^3–^2 gesture over tonic harmony, another defining attribute—appear in bold, distinguishing these from the more flexible elements. The example illustrates how the beginnings and endings of the phrases are more melodically defined, whereas the middles are more flexible.[10] The two non-bold scale degrees followed by question marks—^8 in bar 3 and ^5 in bar 6—indicate scale degrees commonly found in those positions, but without enough frequency to be considered defining attributes. The I–V–I progression in the second phrase is definitely the most common, but, as we'll see in the following section, the scheme remains recognizable even in realizations where this part of the progression is significantly different.

[10]Even the phrase endings, though, show more variation that the graphic illustration conveys. Skip James's "How Long Buck" (1931), for instance, entirely conforms to the graph in its phrase rhythm and harmonic progression, but his first phrase ends unusually on ♭^3.

A Floating Ballad Text

Musicians usually associate the ballad-meter form of "Stackolee" with one of the ballad schemes, taking on that pattern's harmonic progression and degree of melodic fixity. Ma Rainey's "Stack O'Lee Blues" (**Ex. 10[a]**), for instance, combines the "Stackolee" lyrics with the "Frankie and Johnny" scheme, and uses not only the "Frankie" harmonic progression but also the "Frankie" tune. But other combinations of this scheme and text, such as Woody Guthrie's "Stackolee" (**Ex. 10[b]**), have idiosyncratic melodic designs, in keeping with musicians' perception of the pattern as a vehicle for many original tunes. (Guthrie's expansion of the refrain is discussed below.)

When musicians combine the "Stackolee" lyrics with the "Railroad Bill" scheme, on the other hand, they perceive the pattern as doubly predetermined by harmony and melody, and so use only close variants of the "Railroad Bill" tune, observing the melody's narrower range for variation. Furry Lewis, for instance, in his "Billy Lyons and Stack O'Lee" (**Ex. 11[a]**), sings a veritable model of the "Railroad Bill" tune: the first phrase briefly accents ^5 before dropping to a prolonged ^3; the second phrase extends ^3 before continuing the descent to ^1 over IV in bar 7, then closes with a quick swerve back up to ^2; and the third phrase traces a clear ^3–^2–^1 descent. In Long "Cleve" Reed and Little Harvey Hull's "Original Stack O' Lee" Blues" (**Ex. 11[b]**), Hull sings a close variant, prolonging ^3 throughout the entire first phrase, descending to ^2 over the chromatic substitution of III♯ in bars 5–6, and resolving to ^1 over IV in bars 7–8. The defining degrees of the melodic contour appear above the staff.

In the refrain, the "Stackolee" lyrics likewise conform to the characteristic rhythmic profile of each scheme. The two-accent refrain of the "Frankie" scheme combines with two-accent “Stackolee” refrains, such as Mississippi John Hurt’s “That bad man, oh, cruel Stackolee” (**Ex. 12[a]**), with “bad” and “Stack-” falling on the downbeats of bars 9 and 11, together with the shifts to V and I, respectively (see also Ex. 10[a]). Woody Guthrie even goes so far as to double the length of his last phrase (**Ex. 12[b]**), so that his relatively wordy refrain (“He was a bad man, that mean old Stackolee”) avoids the sense of three equally spaced accents—i.e., so that he maintains the rhythmic profile of the “Frankie” refrain and avoids the rhythmic profile of the “Railroad Bill” refrain. In a hypothetical version of the refrain without the expansion **(Ex. 12[c]**), there are three equally spaced downbeat accents, but the second one, on “mean,” has no corresponding harmonic shift. As shown in an interpretation on a higher hypermetric level (**Ex. 12[d]**), Guthrie’s expansion puts “mean” in a weaker hypermetric position than either “bad” or “-lee,” which both fall on hypermetric downbeats. Guthrie correspondingly expands the end of the refrain (Ex. 12[b]), so that “bad” and “-lee” each initiate a four-bar group. He thus effectively doubles the length of the typical “Frankie” refrain, leaving the proportions of its rhythmic profile entirely intact.[11]

The “Railroad Bill” scheme, by contrast, combines with three-accent “Stackolee” refrains, such as Lewis’s “When you lose your money, Lyons, you lose” (**Ex. 13[a]**), or Reed and Hull’s “And it’s oh, Stackolee” (**Ex. 13[b]**), both of which have accents on the downbeats of bars 9, 10, and 11, together with the shifts to I, V, and I, respectively.

[11]Guthrie’s expansion “resembles the rhythmic technique of ‘augmentation,’ in which the durational values of the individual notes of an idea are systematically increased so that the original proportional relations among the durations is retained (i.e., doubled or quadrupled)” (Caplin 1998, 20). Guthrie’s second verse, shown in Examples 10(b) and 12(b), gives the most balanced elongation of the refrain, an exact doubling; many of the verses have more irregular elongations.

The AB form of “Stackolee” typically combines with the “How Long” scheme, as in Lucious Curtis and Willie Ford’s “Stagolee” from 1940 (**Ex. 14[a]**). The melody is clearly an example of the “How Long” tune, opening with a descending ^3–^2 gesture over tonic harmony, with ^1–♭^7 in the accompaniment, followed by a caesura in position 4; a later verse has the ^1–♭^7 opening in the vocal part. But the melody also represents yet another variant: the conclusion of the first phrase on ^1 follows a descent through the narrow range of a third; and the second phrase begins again on ^3, instead of the more common ^1 or ^5. In addition to the seven obligatory downbeat accents, the melody has all four of the “optional” accents, in positions 2 (both phrases), 6 (first phrase), and 4 (second phrase), making the maximum eleven—all but one (bar 1 position 2) falling in anticipatory positions—as indicated by the boxed metric positions above the staff. And the song further demonstrates the scheme’s harmonic flexibility: the first phrase has the most common progression, I–I–IV–IV, but the second phrase has a IV–IV–I–I progression, which may be unique in realizations of the “How Long” scheme. Despite this departure from the more common progression, the song retains the defining elements of the “How Long” scheme, and is clearly recognizable as a realization of the pattern.

The Lomaxes publish this same combination of AB poetic form, 7, 5 phrase rhythm, and “How Long” melodic design—with the ^1–♭^7 opening—in 1934 (**Ex. 14[b]**); they don’t provide any explicit harmonization, but based on the melody’s emphasis on tonic degrees in bars 1–2 and subdominant degrees in bars 3–4, the reader can easily infer a I–I–IV–IV progression in the first phrase. This transcription also has the common caesuras in positions 2, 4, and 6 in the first phrase. Many later versions of

"Stackolee" likewise combine with the "How Long" scheme, including the rhythm and blues artist Archibald's "Stack A'lee (Parts I and II)" from 1950 (**Ex. 14[c]**) and Wilson Pickett's "Stagger Lee" from 1968 (**Ex. 14[d]**). Pickett's harmonic progression is the most common one, whereas Archibald's once again demonstrates the scheme's allowance for harmonic variation. The III♯ in bar 2 both prolongs the opening tonic and functions as an alternative type of applied dominant to the following IV (an alternative to $\mathrm{I}^{\flat 7}$); and the ♭VI in bar 4 prolongs the subdominant.[12] Archibald's III♯ in bar 2 precludes the typical ^1–♭^7 motion, so he replaces it with a with a ^1–♮^7 descent and still retains the opening ^3–^2 motion, both gestures now in the accompaniment.

Textual Crosspollination and Divergence

Finally, the combination of the "Stackolee" text with different schemes reveals remarkable processes of textual exchange and divergence. First, through its combination with the "Frankie and Johnny" scheme, the twelve-bar, ABR "Stackolee" ballad crosspollinates with the "Frankie" ballad, incorporating some of the latter's lyrics and themes, and "Stackolee" in turn occasionally imparts its own themes to the "Frankie" ballad. Second, the combination of the eight-bar, AB "Stackolee" with the "How Long" scheme creates a divergent branch of the song, whereby musicians associate certain lyrics and themes only with the phrase rhythm and poetic form of the eight-bar pattern.

The oldest exchanges are between "Frankie and Johnny" and "Stackolee," and some of their shared couplets go back so far that it might be impossible to tell which

[12]On III as a tonic and VI as a subdominant, see, for example, Everett (2001, 359–60) and Biamonte (2010, 96–97, 101).

ballad they appeared in first. For example, one of the most common opening lines of "Frankie and Johnny," which is recorded as early as 1909, describes her as a "good woman" or "good girl," and closes with "everybody knows" in the rhyming position; but this same formulation also frequently opens "Stackolee," going at least as far back as 1911, where it appears "flipped" to describe him as a "bad man" or a "bully man" or some close variant, which, again, "everybody knowed":

> Frankie was a good woman, everybody knows
> She spent one hundred dollars for to buy her man some clothes
> Oh, he was her man, but he done her wrong
> (1909; after Lomax and Lomax [1934, 103])

> Stagolee was a bully man, and everybody knowed
> When they see Stagolee comin', to give Stagolee the road
> O that man, bad man, Stagolee done come
> (After Odum [1911, 288])

Similarly, early versions of both ballads often have a couplet near the end describing the victim's final trip to the cemetery or graveyard in a "hack" (a taxi), which falls in the rhyming position:

> And now it's rubber-tired carriages, and a rubber-tired hack
> Took old Albert to the graveyard and brought his mother back

His soul's in hell, his soul's in hell
(After Lomax and Lomax [1934, 105]; Laws [1964, 91])

Forty-dollar coffin, eighty-dollar hack,
Carried poor man to the cemetery but failed to bring him back
Everybody been dodgin' Stagolee
(After Odum [1911, 289]; Laws [1964, 91])

Other lyrical exchanges first appear on recordings, and the direction of the exchange is easier to identify, especially in combinations of the "Stackolee" text with the "Frankie" scheme. Ma Rainey, for instance, simply inserts the most common "Frankie" refrain—"He was my man, but he done me wrong"—directly into her "Stack O'Lee Blues":

Stackolee was a bad man, everybody knowed
And when they see Stack O'Lee comin' they give him the road
He was my man, but he done me wrong
(Ma Rainey, "Stack O'Lee Blues, 1925)

It's a remarkable substitution, given that the refrain has nothing to do with the conventional "Stackolee" ballad. The combination of "Stackolee" couplets with the "Frankie" refrain shows how strongly Rainey associates both sets of lyrics with the scheme, rather than with either particular song, and how she feels free to fuse their lyrical elements together, because they fit organically within the same musical pattern.[13]

Woody Guthrie's "Stackolee" likewise borrows lyrics from "Frankie." As mentioned, one of the most common opening "Frankie" lines mentions her goodness, which "everybody knows." The most common rhyming line expounds upon her virtue by noting how much she paid for Johnny's (or Albert's) "suit of clothes," which forms the rhyme:

> Frankie was a good girl, everybody knows
> She paid a hundred dollars for Albert's one suit of clothes
> He's her man, and he done her wrong
> (Mississippi John Hurt, "Frankie," 1928)

As was also mentioned, some versions of "Stackolee" flip this opening line to convey his malevolence, which, again, "everybody knowed." And the rhyming line explains that Stackolee is so intimidatingly fearsome that everyone "gives him the road," as in Odum's and Rainey's couplets, transcribed above. But Guthrie retains the second line of the "Frankie" couplet, concerning the price of the "suit of clothes," the profligate spending now evidence of Stackolee's badness instead of Frankie's goodness:

> Stackolee was a bad man, and everybody knows

[13]Brown (2003, 146) argues that Rainey "confused the lyrics of Stagolee with those of 'Frankie and Johnny,'" but in fact this musical pattern is the most natural setting for this refrain.

Spent a hundred dollars for just one suit of clothes

He was a bad man, that mean old Stackolee

(Woody Guthrie, "Stackolee," 1944)

Conversely, there are also some, if seemingly fewer, instances where the "Stackolee" lyrics rub off on the "Frankie" song—as a result of the "Stackolee" ballad's long association with the "Frankie" scheme. In the fifth verse of Big Bill Broonzy's "Frankie and Johnny," for instance, Stackolee's trademark Stetson hat now belongs to Johnny:

Johnny pulled off his Stetson hat, hollered "Now, baby, don't shoot"

Frankie pressed her finger on the trigger and that gun went rooty toot

She killed her man 'cause he done her wrong

(Big Bill Broonzy, "Frankie and Johnny," 1957, fifth verse)

These borrowings and amalgamations demonstrate that musicians link words and lines not only to particular ballads but also to specific musical patterns. The lyrical formulations easily cross from one ballad to the other because "Frankie" and "Stackolee" combine with the same scheme, which becomes the site of lyrical exchange.

The eight-bar "How Long" scheme, on the other hand, is so different from ballad meter in its rhythmic profile that its combination with the "Stackolee" text engenders a corresponding divergence in lyrical content. Singers still relate the key elements of the "Stackolee" story in the eight-bar version—the altercation over Stackolee's hat, Billy's pleading for sympathy for his wife and children—but there are lines that characterize the eight-bar form that are apparently absent from the twelve-bar form. Among the more evocative of these lyrics are the narrator's description of their dog barking at two men gambling in the dark, becoming an eyewitness to the events;[14] Stackolee and Billy's disagreement, while gambling at night, about the roll of a seven or an eight; and Stackolee's various hijinks with the devil upon his arrival in hell,[15] as in the following couplets:

> It was early one mornin' when I heard my little dog bark
> Stagolee and Billy Lyon was arg'in in the dark
>
> Stagolee and Billy Lyon was gamblin' one night late,
> Stagolee fell seven, Billy Lyon, he fell cotch eight
>
> Stagolee took the pitchfork an' he laid it on the shelf—
> "Stand back, Tom Devil, I'm gonna rule Hell by myself"
> (After Lomax and Lomax [1934, 96, 99])
>
> It was late last night, I heard my bulldog bark
> Stackolee and Billy Lyons they was arguing in the dark

[14]For an early and possibly unique example of the "bulldog" couplet in the twelve-bar "Frankie and Johnny" (not "Stackolee"), collected in 1909, see Perrow (1915, 178), cited in Hudson (1936, 189).

[15]Both the Lomax and Archibald versions have additional "devil" couplets beyond those given here.

Stackolee, he told the devil: “Come on, let’s have some fun
You get your pitchfork, I’m gonna get my forty-one”
(Lucious Curtis and Willie Ford, “Stagolee,” 1940)

I was standin’ on the corner, when I heard my bulldog bark
They were barkin’ at the two men who were gamblin’ in the dark

It was Stackolee and Billy, two men who gambled late
Stackolee throwed seven, Billy swore that he throwed eight

Now the devil heard a rumbling, a mighty rumbling under the ground
Said: “That must be mister Stack turnin’ Billy upside down”
(Archibald, “Stack A’lee [Parts I and II],” 1950, first, second, and thirteenth verses)

I was standin’ on the corner, when I heard my bulldog bark
He was barkin’ at two men who was gamblin’ in the dark

It was Stagger Lee and Billy, two men who gambled late
Stagger Lee threw seven, Billy swore that he threw eight
(Wilson Pickett, “Stagger Lee,” 1968)

The repeated appearance of these couplets in the eight-bar form—and their absence from the twelve-bar form—shows how the combination of “Stackolee” with the “How Long” scheme leads to a divergent branch of the song, with its own subset of lyrics and themes. The lyrical crosspollination and divergence that appear in the two forms of “Stackolee” demonstrate that singers associate lyrics not only with stories but also with musical patterns like phrase rhythm, poetic form, harmonic progression, harmonic rhythm, and melodic design—that they associate lyrics with schemes.

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